

PEOPLE PHOTOGRAPHY

Natural-Light Portraits & Posing

Flattering Light and Relaxed Poses, Every Time

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What's Inside

Flattering Light and Relaxed Poses, Every Time. Written for hobbyists photographing family, friends, and clients.

01 The Portrait Is 90% Light and Rapport

02 See & Shape Natural Light

03 The Bad-Light Fixes

04 Gear & Settings for Flattering Portraits

05 Backgrounds & Composition

06 Directing People So They Relax

07 A Posing Library

08 Backlighting & Flare Without Blowing It

09 Skin-Tone-Friendly Editing

10 Run a Smooth 20-Minute Mini Session

INTRODUCTION

The Portrait Is 90% Light and Rapport

The photographers whose portraits make you stop scrolling are not shooting better cameras than you. They are standing their subject in better light and making that subject feel at ease. Master those two things — where you put a person and how you make them feel — and a phone in portrait mode will outshoot a \$3,000 camera used carelessly. This guide is entirely about those two things.

New photographers spend years chasing gear, convinced the next lens is the missing piece. Meanwhile the working portrait shooter down the street is getting stunning results with a modest kit, because they learned the parts that actually move the needle: **reading light like a language, and directing people so they forget the camera is there.**

Everything in this guide works with whatever you own right now. A DSLR, a mirrorless body, or a phone with a portrait mode — the principles do not care. Where a camera setting has a different name on different brands, we say so. Where a phone does it differently, we say that too.

THE WHOLE GUIDE IN ONE SENTENCE

Find flattering light, put your subject in it, and give them something to do — the "great photo" happens almost by itself after that.

How to use this guide

Chapters 2 and 3 teach you to see and fix light — read them first, because light is the foundation everything else sits on. Chapters 4 and 5 cover the technical and compositional choices that flatter faces. Chapters 6 and 7 are the human half: directing people and a deep library of repeatable poses you can pull out the moment someone freezes up. The last three chapters cover backlighting, skin-friendly editing, and a repeatable session flow you can run start to finish.



Works with any camera — or a phone

If you are shooting on a phone, use the dedicated Portrait mode for the background blur, tap the face to set focus and exposure, and lock it before you shoot. Every lighting, posing, and directing idea in this guide applies to you unchanged — those are the parts that matter most anyway.

CHAPTER 1

See & Shape Natural Light

Before you think about poses or settings, learn to see light the way a portrait photographer sees it. Light has a *direction*, a *quality*, and a *color*, and those three things decide whether a face looks luminous or unflattering long before you press the shutter. The best part: natural light is free, and it is everywhere once you know how to spot the good stuff.

Direction: where the light comes from

Turn a person slowly in any light and watch their face change. The direction the light hits from is the single biggest lever you have, and it is completely free to change — you just move the person or move yourself.

Front light

Light behind **you**, hitting the face flat-on. Even and easy, but it flattens features and can make people squint. Safe, a little boring.

Side light

Light from 45–90° to the side. Creates gentle shadow across the face that reveals shape and depth. This is the flattering, dimensional look.

Back light

Light behind the **subject**. Rims the hair with glow, gives soft dreamy skin. Trickier to expose — Chapter 8 is all about it.

For most flattering portraits, aim for light coming from the side and slightly in front — think of it as "over the photographer's shoulder but off to one side." That angle sculpts the face without burying half of it in shadow.



The short-light rule that instantly flatters

Turn the face slightly *away* from the light so the shadow side is the side nearer the camera. This "short lighting" slims the face and adds drama. Turning the lit side toward the camera ("broad lighting") widens the face — useful occasionally, but short lighting flatters almost everyone.

Quality: hard light vs. soft light

Hard light comes from a small or distant source (bare midday sun) and throws sharp, dark-edged shadows that dig into every pore and wrinkle. Soft light comes from a large, close, or diffused source and wraps around the face, filling shadows gently. **Soft light flatters skin. Almost always, softer is better for portraits.**

The bigger the light source relative to your subject, the softer the light. A cloudy sky is the biggest softbox in the world.

Open shade — the beginner's best friend

Open shade is the soft, shadowed area next to a building, under an awning, beneath a tree canopy, or on the shady side of the street. The subject is out of direct sun but still facing the big open sky, which acts as a giant soft source. It is the most reliably flattering, foolproof light there is. When in doubt on a sunny day, walk your subject into open shade and you are 80% of the way to a good portrait.



Watch the color of your shade

Shade next to a red brick wall or under green leaves bounces that color onto the skin. Pull your subject a step out toward open sky, or put a neutral surface (a lit sidewalk, a light wall) in front of them to bounce clean light back into the face.

Overcast — a giant softbox for free

Beginners groan when the sky goes gray, but an overcast day is a professional gift: the entire sky becomes one enormous diffused light source. Skin looks smooth, shadows are gentle, and you can shoot in any direction all day long. The only catch is that flat overcast light can look a touch lifeless, so add direction back in by placing your subject near a doorway, under the edge of a porch, or beside a wall — anything that blocks light from one side and restores a sense of shape.

The window — a studio you already own

A large window with indirect light (no direct sun beaming through) is a beautiful, controllable soft source. Turn off the room lights so you are not mixing colors, and position your subject beside the window, not facing it.

Classic window-light portrait

STARTING POINT

Subject 45° to window

Camera between window & subject

Distance 2-4 ft from glass

Room lights OFF

Closer to the window = softer, more wraparound light with faster fall-off into shadow. Farther = more even, less dramatic. Add a white foam board or even a bedsheet on the shadow side to bounce a little fill.

Color: golden hour and the warmth of light

The hour after sunrise and the hour before sunset — "golden hour" — gives you low, warm, soft light that skims across faces and makes almost anyone glow. The sun is low enough to act as a giant soft side- or back-light, and the warm color is universally flattering. If you can choose when to shoot, choose here. Midday overhead sun is the hardest light of the day to work with; the ends of the day are the easiest and prettiest.

Golden hour backlit portrait

FIELD-TESTED

Sun behind subject

Aperture f/2-f/2.8

Meter on the face

White balance **Shade/Cloudy** to keep warmth

Put the sun behind your subject's head for a hair-rim glow, then expose for their face (it will look bright, that's right). Shade a stray sunbeam off your lens with your hand to protect contrast.

Catchlights: the spark that makes eyes alive

A catchlight is the little reflection of the light source in your subject's eyes. It is the difference between eyes that sparkle and eyes that look dead. Every good portrait has them. To find them, watch your subject's eyes as you turn them — when you see two bright reflections appear, you have found your light. If the eyes look flat and dark, turn the face up toward the open sky or the window until the catchlights pop in.



Try this: the catchlight walk

Take one willing friend outside and slowly walk them in a full circle while watching only their eyes through the viewfinder. Notice exactly where the catchlights appear, where shadows fall pleasingly, and where the face goes flat or harsh. Five minutes of this teaches your eye more than any diagram.

REMEMBER

Do not fix bad light in editing — fix it by moving your subject two steps into better light before you shoot.

CHAPTER 2

The Bad-Light Fixes

You will not always get soft golden light on demand. Life happens at noon, under trees, in kitchens with ugly ceiling bulbs. The pro move is not to avoid bad light — it is to *reposition your subject* so the same bad light becomes usable. Here are the three worst offenders and the exact save for each.

Problem: harsh midday sun

Symptom: raccoon-eye shadows, squinting, blown-out foreheads, hard black shadows under the nose.

Fix: Get out of it. Walk into open shade (building side, awning, tree line). If there is truly no shade, turn the subject so the sun is *behind* them and expose for the face — instant backlit save. Last resort: have them look down and bring their face up on your count so they are not squinting.

Problem: dappled tree light

Symptom: ugly bright blotches and dark spots scattered across the face from sun poking through leaves.

Fix: Move the subject fully *under* the canopy into consistent open shade, or fully out of it. The blotchy zone is the edge of the tree's shadow — never pose there. Walk them 5–10 feet deeper into solid shade and the mess disappears.

Problem: overhead indoor light

Symptom: shadows in the eye sockets, under the nose and chin; a sickly greenish or orange cast.

Fix: Turn off the overhead bulbs and move the subject to a window — daylight from the side beats a ceiling bulb every time. If you must use room light, have them tilt the chin up toward the light so the sockets fill in.

Problem: harsh mixed street light

Symptom: half the face in hot sun, half in deep shade; competing colors.

Fix: Rotate the subject until the transition line runs cleanly down or off the face rather than splitting it. Or step them into the doorway of the nearest building for clean, directional window-style light.

Pro habit: put the sun at their back

When caught in harsh light with nowhere to hide, your single most reliable move is to turn the subject so the sun lights the back of their head and expose for the now-shaded face. You trade a harsh front-lit face for a soft, glowing, backlit one. It works nearly every time — the full technique is in Chapter 8.

Gear note: the one accessory worth carrying

A collapsible 5-in-1 reflector (often under \$25) folds to the size of a plate and bounces light back into shadowed faces, softens direct sun through its diffuser panel, and shades your lens. It is the cheapest, highest-impact portrait tool you can buy. A white foam board or even a car sunshade does the same job in a pinch.

CHAPTER 3

Gear & Settings for Flattering Portraits

Light and rapport do the heavy lifting, but a handful of technical choices make faces look their best. None of this requires expensive gear — it is about using what you have with intent.

Focal length: why the lens changes the face

Here is a fact that surprises most beginners: **your focal length changes the shape of a person's face**. Wide lenses (anything under ~35mm) exaggerate whatever is closest to the camera — get close for a headshot and the nose balloons, the forehead swells, the ears shrink. Longer lenses compress features into flattering, natural proportions.

Focal length	Best for	Effect on the face
24–35mm	Environmental portraits, groups, tight spaces	Distorts if close; keep the subject in the scene, not filling the frame
50mm	Full-length & half-length, everyday portraits	Natural, close to how the eye sees; versatile all-rounder
85mm	Head-and-shoulders, classic portraits	The portrait sweet spot — flattering compression, beautiful blur
105–135mm	Tight headshots, candid distance	Maximum flattery and background blur; needs room to back up



The lazy rule that always flatters

Zoom with your feet to a focal length of **50mm or longer** and back up until the subject fills the frame the way you want. The distance you gain by standing back is what flattens the nose and rounds out the face naturally. On a phone, use the 2× or 3× "telephoto" lens for portraits rather than the main wide lens — same principle.

Aperture: the creamy background

A wide aperture (low f-number) blurs the background into soft color, separating your subject from clutter and drawing all attention to the face. This is the "professional" look people chase. For portraits, f/1.8 to f/2.8 gives you that melty background; f/4 keeps a little more of the scene when you want context or need more of a group in focus.

Wide open has a catch — focus gets razor thin

At $f/1.4$ – $f/1.8$ the sharp zone can be shallower than the width of a face. Focus on the near eye and it holds; drift to the nose and the eyes go soft. For a single person, $f/1.8$ is glorious. For two people, stop down to $f/2.8$ – $f/4$ so both faces land in focus. For a group of five, $f/5.6$ or more.

Shutter speed for people

People are never perfectly still — they breathe, sway, blink, and shift. Keep your shutter at **$1/125$ s or faster** for posed portraits and $1/250$ s or faster if there are kids or any movement. Below $1/125$ s you risk soft faces even when everyone is "holding still."

Focus: the near eye, always

Sharp eyes read as a sharp portrait even if the ears go soft; soft eyes ruin an otherwise perfect frame. Take control of focus so it lands where it must.

1

Switch to Single-Point AF.

You place one point exactly on the eye rather than letting the camera guess and grab the nose or shoulder.

2

Turn on Eye-AF if your camera has it.

Modern mirrorless bodies (and phones) detect and lock onto the eye automatically — the biggest sharpness upgrade of the decade for portraits.

3

Focus on the eye nearest the camera.

When a face is turned, the near eye is the target. If it is sharp, the portrait works.

4

Use Single AF (AF-S / One-Shot) for posed shots, Continuous (AF-C / AI Servo) for movement.

Match the mode to whether your subject is holding still or walking around.

Outdoor portrait, open shade or golden hour

STARTING POINT

Aperture **f/2**

Shutter **1/250s**

ISO **100-400**

AF **Single-point / Eye-AF**

Lens **50-85mm**

Aperture Priority (A / Av) is perfect here: you set f/2, the camera picks the shutter, and you nudge exposure compensation brighter for pale skin or high-key looks.

Indoor window portrait

STARTING POINT

Aperture **f/2.2**

Shutter **1/160s**

ISO **400-1600**

WB **Daylight (lights off)**

If the shutter dips below 1/125s, raise ISO before you let the shutter slow — a little grain beats a soft face.

CHAPTER 4

Backgrounds & Composition

A beautiful face against a messy background is a wasted photo. Composition is how you make the viewer look exactly where you want and keep everything else quiet. The good news is that portraits follow a few simple, repeatable rules.

Separate the subject from the background

You want your subject to pop off the background, not blend into it. Three levers do this:

1

Distance.

Move your subject well *away* from the background — the farther the wall or trees are behind them, the more those elements blur out. A person standing against a wall has a busy sharp backdrop; the same person ten feet in front of it floats against soft color.

2

Aperture.

A wide aperture (f/1.8–f/2.8) melts a distant background into smooth tones. Combine distance and aperture for maximum separation.

3

Tone and color.

Place a light-haired subject against a darker background and a dark-haired one against lighter tones so edges do not merge.

Compression: use a longer lens to simplify

Longer focal lengths (85mm+) "compress" the background, magnifying distant elements and narrowing the field of view so you capture less clutter and bigger, softer blur. A telephoto lets you turn a chaotic park into a wash of green behind your subject. It is the fastest way to a clean, professional-looking background.



Hunt for clean backgrounds first

Before you pose anyone, look *past* where they will stand. A plain wall, a hedge, an open field, a garage door, deep shade — anything simple and uniform. Watch for trees or poles that will "grow" out of your subject's head, and bright hot spots that pull the eye. Composing a great background before the person arrives is half the battle.

Framing rules that flatter

Eye placement

Put the eyes on the upper third of the frame (rule of thirds). Eyes are where we look first — give them a strong, natural position rather than dead center.

Headroom

Leave a little space above the head — not too much, not a haircut crop at the top. For tight headshots, it is fine and stylish to crop slightly into the top of the hair.

Negative space

Empty, uncluttered space around the subject gives the eye room to rest and makes the portrait feel intentional and calm. Great for storytelling frames.

Looking room

If the subject looks off to one side, leave more space on that side so their gaze has somewhere to go. Crowding the look feels claustrophobic.

Where to crop the body

Never crop at a joint

Cropping right at the wrist, elbow, knee, or ankle makes people look amputated. Crop through the middle of a limb segment instead — mid-thigh, mid-forearm, mid-calf. And never crop at the neck or the top of the head. When in doubt, give yourself room and crop later.

Environmental vs. tight portraits

An **environmental portrait** uses a wider lens and includes the setting — a baker in the kitchen, a musician in the studio — to tell a story about who the person is. A **tight portrait** fills the frame with the face and is all about expression and connection. Both are valid; decide which you are making before you shoot so your lens choice, distance, and background all serve the same goal.

CHAPTER 5

Directing People So They Relax

This is the skill that separates snapshots from portraits, and almost nobody teaches it. Your camera settings can be perfect and the light gorgeous, but if your subject is stiff and self-conscious, the photo dies. Your real job on a shoot is to make a slightly nervous human feel comfortable, confident, and alive. Here is how.

Nobody knows what to do with their body in front of a camera. Your subject is not a bad model — they are simply waiting for you to tell them what to do.

Give confident, specific direction

The number one reason people look awkward is that they are guessing. "Just be natural" is the cruelest thing you can say to someone who has no idea what to do. Replace it with clear, physical instructions: "Turn your shoulders toward that tree, now look back at me over your shoulder." "Put your hand in your pocket, leave the thumb out." "Shift your weight onto your back foot." People relax the instant they are given a job, because now they are not responsible for inventing something.



Pro habit: never let the energy die in silence

Keep talking the entire time. Silence makes people anxious and self-aware. Narrate what you are doing ("this looks great, one second while I fix my focus"), give a steady stream of small direction, and react out loud to good moments ("yes — that, right there!"). Positive feedback is rocket fuel; the more you tell someone they look great, the more they believe it and the better they look.

Talk to them, and use their name

Ask questions between frames — about their kids, their trip, their dog. When someone is telling a story they care about, their face comes alive and their body forgets the camera. Some of the best expressions happen in the half-second after someone finishes talking. Keep shooting through the conversation, not just when you say "ready."

Getting a real smile — the fake laugh

Say "cheese" and you get a tight, dead grin. Instead, ask them to *fake a laugh* — a big obviously-fake "ha ha ha." It feels silly, everyone knows it is fake, and that awkwardness tips over into a genuine laugh about two seconds later. Fire

your burst right as the real one breaks through. Other reliable triggers: ask them to look away, take a breath, and look back on your count; or have them say something ridiculous.

Try this: the reset breath

When a subject freezes up or a smile goes stale, stop and say: "Let's reset — shake it out, drop your shoulders, take a big breath, and look back at me." This five-second reset clears the tension out of the face and body and gives you a fresh, natural expression instead of a fading forced one.

What to do with hands

Hands are where nervousness lives, and stiff or clenched hands wreck an otherwise good pose. Give them a job:

- ☒ Rest a hand lightly on a hip, in a pocket (thumb out), or on the opposite arm.
- ☒ Touch the hair, collar, chin, or a necklace — light, relaxed contact.
- ☒ Hold a prop: a coffee cup, a jacket over the shoulder, sunglasses.
- ☒ Keep hands soft and slightly curled, never flat-palmed to the camera or in a tight fist.
- ☒ Show the edge of the hand to the lens, not the wide flat back, so hands stay small and graceful.

Posture tricks that flatter everyone

Shift the weight

Put weight on the back foot. It pops the hip, bends the front knee, and creates a relaxed, flattering S-curve instead of a stiff soldier stance.

Angle the body

Turn shoulders 30–45° off the camera rather than facing square-on. Square shoulders look wide; angled shoulders look slimmer and more dynamic.

Chin forward & down

Have them push the forehead slightly toward you and drop the chin a touch. It sharpens the jawline and eliminates any double chin. "Turtle it out a little."

Create space at the arms

Ask them to lift the arms a hair off the torso (hand on hip does this). Arms mashed against the body look wider; a sliver of daylight slims them.

REMEMBER

You are not photographing a face — you are photographing a feeling. Make them feel great and the great photo takes itself.

CHAPTER 6

A Posing Library

This is the chapter to bookmark. When someone is standing in front of you and your mind goes blank, pull out one of these and build from it. Every pose here is a starting point — set it up, shoot a few frames, then tweak. Give the direction out loud, exactly as written in quotes. Move through them in order and you will never run dry mid-session.

Individuals — standing

1 The confident lean-back.

"Weight on your back foot, front knee soft, shoulders turned toward that wall, now look at me." Angled body, relaxed hips, chin forward and down. Your bread-and-butter standing pose.

2 Hands in pockets.

"Both hands in your front pockets, thumbs out, roll your shoulders back." Instantly casual and solves the hand problem. Great for men especially.

3 The hair touch.

"Bring one hand up and run it through the side of your hair, keep it relaxed, look off toward the light." Adds motion and softness; wonderful in backlight.

4 Walking toward you.

"Walk slowly straight at me, look down, then look up on 'three' — one, two, three." Continuous AF, burst mode. The most natural-looking "posed" shot there is.

5 Over-the-shoulder.

"Turn your back mostly to me, then twist and look back over your shoulder." Slimming, flirty, flattering for nearly everyone.

Individuals — leaning

1 Shoulder on a wall.

"Lean one shoulder into the wall, cross your ankles, hook a thumb in your pocket." Relaxed, editorial, gives the body a natural line.

2**Back against the wall.**

"Lean your back flat on the wall, drop one foot up against it behind you, hands loose." Confident and grounded; the wall does the posing work.

3**Lean on a railing or car.**

"Rest your forearms on the rail, lean your weight into it, and look out toward the view." Gives arms and hands a purpose and creates a relaxed slump.

Individuals — seated

1**Steps or curb.**

"Sit on the step, lean forward, elbows on your knees, hands loosely clasped." Forward lean keeps posture engaged; classic and strong.

2**Seated on the ground.**

"Sit with your knees up, wrap your arms around them, lean toward me a little." Cozy and casual, great for lifestyle and kids.

3**Cross-legged, relaxed.**

"Cross your legs, put one hand behind you for support, let the other rest on your knee." Opens the frame and relaxes the shoulders.

4**Chair, turned.**

"Sit turned 45° to me, drape one arm over the chair back, look toward the window." Angled body slims; the chair gives the arms a home.

**Shoot every pose at three crops**

From each setup, grab a full-length frame, a half-length (waist up), and a tight head-and-shoulders *without moving your subject* — just zoom or step in. One pose becomes three distinct images, and your subject never has to reset. This alone triples your keeper count per session.

Couples

The secret to couples is genuine contact and interaction — pointing them at the camera side by side looks like a hostage photo. Connect them, then direct.

1**The forehead touch.**

"Come close, foreheads together, close your eyes, and just breathe and smile." Intimate, safe, and forgiving; a go-to opener.

2**Hug from behind.**

"You wrap your arms around them from behind, chin on their shoulder; you two, lean back into them." Creates natural height stacking and closeness.

3**Walking hand in hand.**

"Hold hands, walk away from me down the path, then turn and look back at each other." Movement plus connection; shoot a burst.

4**The whisper & laugh.**

"Lean in and whisper something that'll make them laugh." You cannot fake this reaction — it is always real. Fire immediately.

5**Face to face, noses close.**

"Turn toward each other, get close enough your noses almost touch, hands on waist and chest." Turn their bodies slightly toward the camera so you see both faces.

6**Dancing sway.**

"Slow dance — one hand on the waist, the other holding hands up, and sway." Movement loosens stiff couples fast.

Families & groups

Groups panic beginners. The fix is structure: stagger heights, close the gaps, and connect people physically so no one floats alone.

1**Triangle stacking.**

Arrange heads at different heights — some sitting, some standing, some leaning — so the group forms triangles rather than a flat row of shoulders. Rows of equal heads look like a team photo.

2**Close every gap.**

"Everybody squeeze in — shoulders touching, no daylight between you." Space between people reads as emotional distance. Get them uncomfortably close; it looks warm in-camera.

3

Give hands connections.

Arms around waists and shoulders, a hand on a knee, kids on hips or laps. Physical links make a group look like a family instead of a lineup.

4

Put the family in motion.

"Everyone walk toward me together" or "big group hug on three." Motion and interaction break the frozen group stare.

5

Focus and aperture for groups.

Stop down to $f/4$ – $f/5.6$ so every face is sharp, keep everyone on roughly the same focal plane (a shallow arc, not a deep line), and focus on the front row's eyes.

**With kids, drop the plan**

You will not pose a three-year-old. Instead, set your exposure and focus for the light they are playing in, get down to their eye level, and give the parents or the child a game — "tickle fight," "throw them in the air," "everybody run to that tree." Then shoot the real moments in continuous AF and burst. The candid beats the posed every time with young kids.

Candid movement prompts

Motion kills stiffness. When a pose feels frozen, give a physical prompt and shoot through it:

**Walk & look back**

"Walk away, then glance back at me." Natural stride, natural expression, natural everything.

**Spin**

"Spin in place and let the dress or hair fly." Joyful energy, great with backlight and a fast shutter ($1/500s+$).

**Interact**

"Toss the ball, splash the water, share the ice cream." Real activity, real faces.

**Toss & catch**

"Throw the leaves/petals up and watch them fall." Eyes go up and bright, hands get busy.

**Fake laugh**

"Fake-laugh for me — big and dumb." Tips into a real laugh in seconds.

**Reset & return**

"Look down, breathe, look back up on three." Fresh expression on demand.

 Try this: build your five-pose flow

Pick one standing, one leaning, one seated, one movement prompt, and one tight-crop expression shot from this chapter and practice running them back-to-back on a patient friend until you can do it without thinking. That five-pose loop, adjusted on the fly, will carry you through any real session with confidence.

CHAPTER 7

Backlighting & Flare Without Blowing It

Backlight — light coming from behind your subject — creates that dreamy, glowing, magazine-cover look, with a halo of light in the hair and soft, luminous skin. It is also where beginners get burned: they either get a silhouette with a black face, or a washed-out gray sky and a dull subject. Here is how to get the glow and keep the face bright.

Expose for the face, not the sky

When the sun is behind your subject, the background is far brighter than their face. If you let the camera average the scene, it exposes for all that brightness and leaves the face dark. The fix is to **meter off the face** and let the background go bright.

1 Use spot metering, or dial in exposure compensation.

Spot-meter on the cheek, or add +1 to +2 stops of exposure compensation so the face brightens even as the background blows out a little.

2 Let the background go bright — that is correct.

A slightly overexposed, glowy background is the look. A perfectly exposed sky means a face in shadow.

3 On a phone, tap the face and drag the exposure slider up.

Same idea: tell the phone the face is what matters, then brighten.

4 Bounce light back in.

A reflector or a bright wall in front of the subject fills the shaded face so you do not have to overexpose the background as much.



Beware the dull gray sky

If your backlit portrait has a lifeless white-gray sky, you exposed for the face and the sky simply clipped — that is fine if the light glows. But if the *whole image* feels flat and hazy, sun is hitting your lens and killing contrast. Shade the lens (next section) to bring the punch back. Shooting during golden hour rather than midday also keeps the sky a rich color instead of a blown-out gray.

Rim light: position the sun for a halo

Place the sun directly behind the subject's head and it wraps their hair and shoulders in a bright outline that separates them beautifully from the background. Move the subject (or yourself) a few inches until you see that rim appear. It is the single most flattering effect in natural-light portraiture.

Using flare intentionally — and avoiding it when you don't want it

Let a sliver of sun peek past the subject's head or shoulder and it creates warm flare and light streaks across the frame — dreamy when you want it. To *control* it: move slightly so the sun is fully hidden behind your subject for zero flare, or let just an edge show for a controlled kiss of light. When you do not want flare at all, use a lens hood, or raise your hand (or a reflector) just above the frame to shade the front element.

Glowing backlit portrait

FIELD-TESTED

Sun low, behind subject's head

Meter on the face (+1 to +2 EV)

Aperture f/2-f/2.8

Shade the lens with your hand

Shoot at golden hour for the warmest glow. Bring a reflector or position the subject facing a bright surface to lift the shaded face without overcooking the background.



Pro habit: find the edge of the shadow

The most flattering backlight often lives right where the sun grazes past the subject. Move your subject in tiny increments and watch the rim light bloom and fade. An inch of movement transforms the shot — backlighting rewards small, patient adjustments more than any other kind of light.

CHAPTER 8

Skin-Tone-Friendly Editing

Good editing on portraits is invisible — it makes skin look like great skin on a great day, not like plastic or a filter. The golden rule of retouching is restraint: enhance the person, never erase them. Here is a clean, skin-respecting workflow.

Get white balance right first

Everything downstream depends on accurate color, and nothing matters more than skin tone. If your white balance is off, faces go orange, green, or ghostly blue and no amount of later fiddling fully saves them.

1

Shoot in RAW if you can.

RAW lets you correct white balance freely after the fact with no quality loss — a lifesaver for skin.

2

Set white balance by the skin, not a chart.

Adjust temperature and tint until the skin looks like healthy skin — warm but not orange, without a green or magenta cast. Trust your eye on the face above all else.

3

Keep it warm and natural.

Skin almost always looks best a touch on the warm side. When unsure, nudge slightly warmer rather than cooler — cool white balance makes people look sickly.



Watch for color contamination

Green grass, red walls, and colored clothing bounce their color onto the skin. If a face reads slightly green after a shoot in a park, gently pull the tint toward magenta or desaturate the greens/reds a hair until the skin looks natural again.

Gentle skin retouching — do not overdo it

The mistake that screams "amateur edit" is smoothing skin into a poreless mask. Real skin has texture, and keeping it is what makes an edit look professional rather than fake.



Remove only *temporary* things: a stray blemish, a bit of flyaway hair, a piece of lint. Keep permanent features — freckles, moles, laugh lines — that make the person themselves.



Use a healing/spot tool for individual blemishes rather than blanket smoothing.

- ✓ If you smooth skin, do it lightly and preserve texture — dial the effect back until you are not sure it is there, then stop.
- ✓ Reduce redness or blotchiness gently with targeted desaturation rather than painting over the whole face.



The over-editing tells

Plastic, textureless skin; unnaturally white eyes and teeth; orange or gray skin tones; halos around the hair from heavy sharpening; and eyes sharpened into something alien. If your subject looks like a video-game character, pull everything back by half. Under-editing skin almost always looks better than over-editing it.

Dodge & burn to shape the face

Dodging (lightening) and burning (darkening) small areas lets you sculpt a face with light the way a painter would — subtly. Brighten the areas that catch light (forehead, tops of cheeks, bridge of the nose, the eyes) and gently darken areas that recede (under the cheekbones, the jawline). Keep it whisper-light: the goal is dimension, not a contoured mask. This is the finishing touch that makes a portrait feel three-dimensional and intentional.

Color that flatters skin

Aim for warm, natural color overall. Slightly lift the shadows so faces do not go muddy, keep contrast moderate so skin stays soft, and avoid heavy saturation that pushes skin toward orange. A gentle, warm, low-contrast finish flatters nearly every skin tone; harsh contrast and cranked saturation flatter none.



Pro habit: check skin against known-good tones

Step back from the screen and ask, "Does this look like a real person in real light?" Compare to a portrait you love. If your version looks orange, gray, or plastic beside it, ease off. Fresh eyes after a short break catch skin problems your tired eyes miss.

CHAPTER 9

Run a Smooth 20-Minute Mini Session

You now have the light, the settings, the poses, and the editing. This final chapter ties it into a repeatable flow you can run start to finish — whether it is a quick family mini-session or an hour with a friend. A structure means you never stand there wondering what to do next, and your subject always feels like they are in capable hands.

Before they arrive

- ✓ Scout the light and pick two or three spots with good open shade or backlight.
- ✓ Find clean, simple backgrounds at each spot and note where the sun will be.
- ✓ Dial in a starting exposure (Aperture Priority, f/2, Auto ISO, shutter floor 1/200s).
- ✓ Set Single-point AF or Eye-AF and confirm your card has space and battery is charged.
- ✓ Pick your five-pose flow in your head so you can start the moment they arrive.

The session flow, arrival to wrap

1

Minute 0-3 — Warm up.

Greet them, chat, keep it light. Start shooting easy poses immediately (walking toward you, hands in pockets) so they loosen up while the pressure is low. Tell them early and often that they look great.

2

Minute 3-8 — Standing & leaning.

Work your standing and leaning poses at the first spot. Shoot each at three crops. Keep talking, keep reacting, keep the energy up.

3

Minute 8-13 — Seated & connection.

Move to the second spot, get them seated or (for couples/families) connected and interacting. This is where the warm, relaxed frames usually come.

4

Minute 13-17 — Movement & candid.

Break out the movement prompts — walking, spinning, laughing, tossing. Continuous AF, burst mode. Highest-energy, most natural frames of the day.

5

Minute 17-20 — Backlight finish & wrap.

End on a glowing backlit portrait for the hero shot. Then show them one or two frames on the back of the camera — seeing themselves look great sends them off happy and confident.

Your shot checklist

- ✓ A full-length, a half-length, and a tight head-and-shoulders of the individual.
- ✓ At least one genuine laugh (not a posed smile).
- ✓ A connection frame for couples/families (touch, interaction, real closeness).
- ✓ A candid movement frame (walking, spinning, playing).
- ✓ A backlit or golden-hour glow shot for the hero image.
- ✓ A wide environmental frame that shows the setting and tells a story.

**Keep the energy up — it is your job, not theirs**

Your subject mirrors your energy. If you are calm, confident, and having fun, they relax and have fun. If you go quiet and tense while fussing with settings, they tense up too. Sort your technical setup *before* they arrive so that during the session you can give them your full, warm attention. That attention is the real product.

**End before the energy fades**

Twenty focused minutes of a relaxed, happy subject beats an hour of a tired one. Watch for the moment smiles start to flatten and wrap it up on a high note. It is better to stop with everyone wanting one more than to grind out stiff frames at the end.

REMEMBER

Great portraits are not captured — they are created, by putting a person in beautiful light and making them feel beautiful in it. Do those two things and the camera is just the easy part.

Story Mode Guy

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